the State within the meaning of the Federal Constitution." *Hunter* v. *Pittsburgh*, 207 U. S. 161, 178.

In *Dartmouth College* v. *Woodward*, 4 Wheat. 518, it was distinctly recognized that as respects grants of political or governmental authority to cities, towns, counties and the like the legislative power of the States is not restrained by the contract clause of the Constitution, pp. 629–630, 659–664, 668, 694; and in *East Hartford* v. *Hartford Bridge Co.*, 10 How. 511, where was involved the validity of a state statute recalling a grant to a city, theretofore made and long in use, of power to operate and maintain a ferry over a river, it was said, p. 533, that the parties to the grant did not stand "in the attitude towards each other of making a contract by it, such as is contemplated in the Constitution, and as could not be modified by subsequent legislation. The legislature was acting here on the one part, and public municipal and political corporations on the other. They were acting, too, in relation to a public object, being virtually a highway across the river, over another highway up and down the river. From this standing and relation of these parties, and from the subject-matter of their action, we think that the doings of the legislature as to this ferry must be considered rather as public laws than as contracts. They related to public interest. They changed as those interests demanded. The grantees, likewise, the towns being mere organizations for public purposes, were liable to have their public powers, rights, and duties modified or abolished at any moment by the legislature. . . . Hence, generally, the doings between them and the legislature are in the nature of legislation rather than compact, and subject to all the legislative conditions just named, and therefore to be considered as not violated by subsequent legislative changes." In *New Orleans* v. *New Orleans Water Works Co.*, 142 U. S. 79, where a city, relying on the contract clause, sought a review by this court of a